The Fly Tower

High in the timber rafters above the stage hangs the vast rigging of the fly tower. Hand-hewn pulleys of seasoned boxwood guide the oiled hemp cords that once balanced the painted heavens, the moving clouds, and the heavy scenic machinery of Tower III.

The raiders severed the rigging lines to drop the iron proscenium curtain across the stage. Merely hauling on the remaining cords will snap the hemp: Serlio and Sabbatini engineered a dual balance lock to prevent catastrophic collapse.

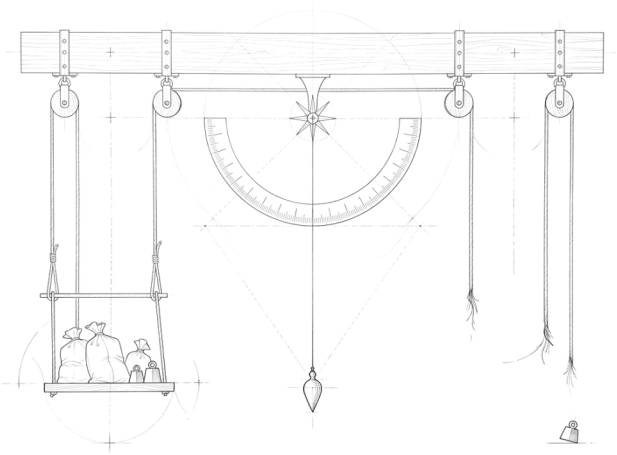


Plate XII - Unified theatrical fly tower rigging (Tower III). Serlio & Sabbatini mechanical system.



I. The Clinometer & Safety Brake
The semicircular clinometer suspended from the tie-beam measures the true horizontal level of the curtain. Settle the plumb-bob exactly upon thirty-eight degrees on the bronze arc: only at this equilibrium does the internal ratchet pawl disengage from the drum, releasing the safety brake.

II. The West Counterweight Cradle
The raiders slashed the eastern lines in haste, locking the proscenium in darkness. Once the safety brake is disengaged, distribute the sandbags and iron ingots upon the west cradle. When the cradle counterweight equals the mass of the curtain, the proscenium raises smoothly.



Field note: If the plumb-line drifts even two degrees from thirty-eight, the iron teeth bite and lock the track. Set the balance first; weigh the cradle second.